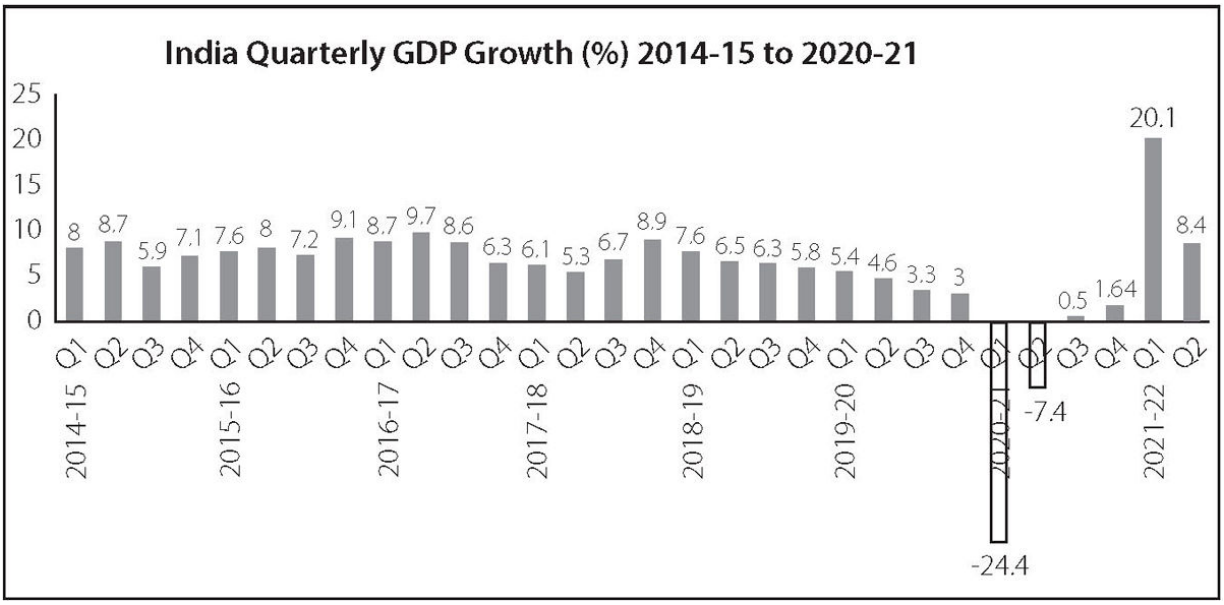


Source: 'Annual and Quarterly Estimates of GDP at Constant Prices: 2011–12 Series', Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation. Available at: http://mospi.nic.in/data[21]

Consider the job numbers when Modi was asking voters for a second term before the April–May 2019 general election. While the quarterly employment survey was being rejigged using a new methodology, and economists continued to argue about the quality of the government's economic numbers overall,[22] survey data from the independent Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy (CMIE) released right in the middle of the poll campaign in April 2019 showed that unemployment had increased to 7 per cent, the highest point since October 2016. It went up to as high as 8 per cent in October 2019 before settling around the 7 per cent mark by December 2019.[23]

Plot these job numbers on a national map and the densest unemployment rates of over 10 per cent were bang in the middle of the BJP's core Hindi heartland base: Rajasthan, Haryana, UP, Bihar and Jharkhand. Madhya Pradesh was not too far behind. Yet, the BJP's majority in Parliament was powered by these same states. In fact, even during the poll campaign here, it wasn't jobs or candidates but other local factors that dominated. In UP, for example, the entire election rested on the caste debate and whether the constituency-level arithmetic of the SP–BSP alliance could trump Modi's chemistry or not. We know that, ultimately, the alliance could not pull it off.